

▶ *On Christmas Day, when Tesla CEO Elon Musk posed as a slim Santa Claus on X, he gave an unmatched public profile to the anti-obesity drugs Mounjaro and Ozempic with one comment. “Like Cocaine Bear, but Santa and Ozempic,” he said, adding, “Technically, Mounjaro, but that does not have the same ring to it.”*

The sudden publicity (Musk has 209 million followers on X) was the icing on the cake. The companies that make these two drugs, Eli Lilly of the US (Mounjaro) and Novo Nordisk of Denmark (Ozempic) are already the darlings of shareholders, with Eli Lilly at No. 13 and Novo Nordisk at No. 25 on a market capitalisation listing. Musk’s Tesla was at No. 8.

So why are people going nuts over these drugs? Cut to a close shot of *aam aadmi* and obesity.

54 | Over 2,000 km from Austin, Texas, where Musk is headquartered, Savita Ahuja, a corporate lawyer based in Miami, Florida, was setting new goals after realising the impact of the new injection: She had lost 13 kg in 10 weeks. Savita, 34, had been on a roller coaster of coffee and junk food, odd hours, and sporadic workouts, with guilt trips into keto and intermittent fasting. But the 5’5” Savita had been stuck at 90 kg.

Till she tried the new weight-loss injection. She

couldn’t wait to share the news with her cousin in India. Her 80 kg cousin had tried every pill, powder, and belt sold on TV shopping channels to lose weight. The cousin’s first question: when would Savita’s drug be available in India?

The cousin won’t have to wait long, as the pharma majors race to grab a global market expected to be worth \$100 billion by the decade’s end. In 2023, Novo Nordisk, which makes semaglutide (marketed as Wegovy for weight loss and Ozempic for diabetes), briefly became Europe’s most valuable company with a market capitalisation of \$424.7 billion, overtaking luxury goods major LVMH and even topping Denmark’s GDP.

Novo Nordisk’s semaglutide and Eli Lilly’s tirzepatide, marketed as Mounjaro, are the rock stars of the pharma market and are eyeing an India entry in the next four-five quarters. Both were developed for managing Type 2 diabetes, in which the body does not produce enough insulin, the hormone that keeps you healthy by shunting excess sugar that floods your blood after a meal into your cells.

2025: A Happy New You

Both semaglutide and tirzepatide target the GLP-1 receptor on cell surfaces and mimic the action of GLP-1 to get the body to produce more insulin, curb hunger and slow food movement from the stomach to the small intestine. In short, you feel less hungry and more full. The result: you lose weight. Clinical trials have shown participants losing up to 20% of their body weight. Four GLP-1 receptor agonists have been approved for obesity treatment: Novo Nordisk’s Wegovy and Saxenda, Eli Lilly’s Zepbound, and Shanghai Benemae Pharmaceutical’s Yishengtai. All these are injectibles.

The good news for India is that Eli Lilly plans to intro-

MAJOR GLOBAL PLAYERS

▶ Among the major global players in the space of weight-loss drugs, Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly are planning to enter India with their offerings in the next two years ▶ Eli Lilly’s Mounjaro could come to India in 2025, followed by Novo Nordisk’s Wegovy in 2026

ROCHE

Xenical (orlistat)

NOVO NORDISK

Wegovy (semaglutide)
Saxenda (liraglutide)
Ozempic (semaglutide)
Rybelsus (oral semaglutide)

ELI LILLY

Mounjaro (tirzepatide)

PFIZER

Danuglipron
Lotiglipron

ASTRAZENECA

Bydureon (exenatide)
Byetta (exenatide)

AMGEN

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